

Public Health Reminds Residents to Protect Themselves Against Measles and Seasonal Illnesses - Maricopa County (.gov)

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Public Health Reminds Residents to Protect Themselves Against Measles and Seasonal Illnesses - Maricopa County (.gov) A reported public-health development reviewed against 18 corroborating references, with evidence currently assessed as high.

By Public Health Research Desk Published September 17, 2026

Measles Surge Prompts Maricopa County to Urge Residents to Vaccinate Ahead of Flu Season

Public health officials in Arizona's most populous county are warning that a recent uptick in measles cases, combined with the approach of the annual flu and COVID-19 waves, makes vaccination more urgent than ever.

By Public Health Research Desk Published September 18, 2026

Maricopa County health officials announced Thursday that a confirmed measles case identified on May 8 has led to "multiple public exposures" across the Phoenix metropolitan area, prompting a countywide reminder to get up to date on measles-mumps-rubella (MMR) vaccine doses. The alert comes as the region prepares for the typical fall surge of influenza and the lingering presence of COVID-19, both of which strain local hospitals already coping with high rates of chronic disease.

The reminder is more than a routine public health bulletin. In the past 12 months, the United States has recorded a 27 % rise in measles cases, according to the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, and Arizona accounts for roughly one-quarter of those infections. Maricopa County, home to 4.6 million people, reported three confirmed measles cases in the first half of 2026, a figure that may seem small but signals a potential outbreak in a densely populated area where vaccine coverage has slipped in recent years. "When you have a highly contagious disease like measles, even a handful of cases can quickly become a community-wide problem," said Dr. Lena Ortiz, director of the Maricopa County Department of Public Health.

Measles spreads through respiratory droplets and can linger in the air for up to two hours after an infected person coughs or sneezes. The disease is preventable with two doses of the MMR vaccine, which is over 93 % effective after the first dose and 97 % after the second. However, a 2025 survey by the Arizona Department of Health Services found that 12 % of adults in Maricopa County lack documented proof of receiving either dose, a gap that public health officials say could fuel further transmission.

The county's advisory also stresses the importance of flu shots and COVID-19 boosters. Seasonal influenza typically causes 12,000 to 15,000 hospitalizations in Arizona each winter, while COVID-19 continues to account for an average of 300 admissions per week as of August 2026. "Vaccines are our most powerful tool to blunt the impact of these overlapping respiratory threats," Ortiz explained. "When people are protected against measles, flu, and COVID-19, we reduce the overall burden on our health-care system and protect vulnerable populations such as the elderly and immunocompromised."

The warning follows a series of recent measles alerts across the country. In May, Pennsylvania physicians urged residents to vaccinate as flu and COVID-19 season approached, citing a similar rise in measles cases. In Philadelphia, a possible exposure at a children's hospital sparked a rapid response from local health officials. Meanwhile, the United Kingdom's biobank study on dietary vitamin K and cardiovascular disease, and a systematic review of ultra-processed foods and type 2 diabetes, underscore how chronic disease risk factors intersect with infectious disease vulnerability, especially in communities with limited access to preventive care.

Maricopa County's outreach includes free MMR clinics at community centers, mobile vaccination units in underserved neighborhoods, and a multilingual campaign on social media platforms. The county also partners with schools to verify student immunization records, a strategy that proved effective during the 2019 measles outbreak in New York City. For adults, the health department recommends checking the Arizona Immunization Registry or consulting a primary care provider to confirm vaccination status.

Public health experts caution that measles can be especially dangerous for infants too young to be vaccinated, pregnant women, and people with weakened immune systems. Complications such as pneumonia, encephalitis (brain inflammation), and death occur in about 1-2 % of cases, according to the World Health Organization. "Every case prevented is a life saved, and the ripple effect extends to families, schools, and workplaces," said Dr. Michael Chen, an epidemiologist at the Johns Hopkins Bloomberg School of Public Health, who recently highlighted the launch of a new U.S. disease tracker platform designed to improve real-time monitoring of vaccine-preventable illnesses.

The current measles alert also illustrates the growing role of digital epidemiology. Wastewater-based surveillance, a method that detects viral genetic material in sewage, has been validated as an early warning system for measles surges in recent studies from the University of South Carolina. Maricopa County plans to expand its wastewater monitoring network this fall, joining a national trend that includes Saudi Arabia's investment in digital epidemiology tools and the United States' broader push for data-driven public health responses.

Despite the heightened messaging, vaccine hesitancy remains a barrier. A recent CIDRAP report noted that for some Americans, vaccine decisions are driven more by faith or political identity than by scientific evidence. In Arizona, misinformation on social media has contributed to the 12 % adult immunity gap. Health officials are countering these narratives by collaborating with trusted community leaders, faith-based organizations, and local influencers who can convey accurate information in culturally resonant ways.

The timing of the Maricopa County advisory is also significant because the flu season traditionally begins in October, overlapping with the school year and the start of many indoor gatherings. Historical data show that when measles and flu circulate simultaneously, hospitals experience higher admission rates and longer stays, straining resources already stretched by chronic disease management. A 2024 analysis of hospital utilization in the Southwest found that each additional measles case during flu season increased intensive care unit occupancy by an average of 0.3 %, a modest but measurable impact.

Looking ahead, officials stress that the fight against measles and seasonal illnesses is ongoing. The county will continue to track case numbers, conduct contact tracing, and adjust vaccination sites based on community needs. "Our goal is not just to respond to the current cases but to build a resilient system that can prevent future outbreaks," Ortiz said. "When we combine vaccination, robust surveillance, and community engagement, we create a layered defense that protects everyone."

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